

Ellipses & Circles

Drawing perfect ovals freehand

Ellipses appear in nearly every drawing — wheels, cups, cylinders, arches, eyes. The ability to draw a clean, confident ellipse freehand is a core skill that takes deliberate practice to develop.

KEY CONCEPTS

What is an Ellipse?

An ellipse is a circle seen in perspective. The degree of the ellipse (how open or closed it is) indicates the viewing angle. A circle viewed straight-on is a full circle (90°); viewed from the side it becomes a flat line (0°).

Major & Minor Axes

Every ellipse has two axes: the major axis (longest diameter) and the minor axis (shortest). These are always perpendicular to each other. Use them as construction guides — draw the axes first, then the ellipse around them.

Drawing Ellipses

Ghost the motion 3–5 times before committing. Draw through the ellipse — complete 2–3 full rotations, then lift. This produces a more confident, symmetrical shape than stopping at one pass. Draw from the shoulder, not the wrist.

Common Mistakes

1) Pointy ends — caused by lifting the pen at the sides; keep the motion going. 2) Flat sides — caused by moving too fast through the middle. 3) Wrong degree — practice matching different degrees (15°, 30°, 45°, 60°, 90°).

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Fill a page with ellipses of varying degrees (flat to round). Ghost each one.
2. Draw a cylinder: two ellipses connected by vertical lines. Repeat in 3 orientations.
3. Draw a glass, cup, or bottle from observation — focus on getting the ellipses right.

FURTHER READING

■ Draw a Box – Ellipses

<https://drawabox.com/lesson/1/2>

■ Proko – How to Draw Ellipses

<https://youtu.be/Zp2-j3e7HJc>